But several recent incidents have shaken the foundations of this arrangement. Four Dalit youths caught skinning a cow were stripped, tied and beaten with iron rods in the state of Gujarat by cow vigilantes who accused them of killing the animal (they had not).[30] Two Dalit women were assaulted in BJP-ruled Madhya Pradesh for carrying cow meat (which turned out, upon inspection, to be buffalo meat and therefore not illegal).[31]

Such incidents have heightened the sense of vulnerability felt by many who do not necessarily share the reverence the vigilantes feel for cows. Yet, for the first time, India has a central government that refuses to disapprove of cow vigilantism. The Minister for Social Justice, whose principal responsibility is to promote the welfare of India's Dalits, regretted not the vigilantes' violence but the fact that they had perpetrated it on the basis of ill-founded rumours.[32] In other words, their mission was so transcendently just that their misbehaviour could be condoned if their targets really had killed or eaten a cow.

The atmosphere of cow fundamentalism enforced by the vigilantes has caused immense economic complications. Many farmers look after their cows with respect, but once they are too old to produce milk, they find it unaffordable to maintain them and quietly sell their cows to butchers (or to those who could transport them across state lines to states where cows could legally be slaughtered). With this option now foreclosed in the present climate, many farmers are being driven into debt by the expense of maintaining unproductive and uneconomic cattle. And the country's population of cows is proving increasingly unsustainable.[33]

It is not a coincidence that 63 per cent of atrocities against Dalits because of cow vigilantism occur in just four states—U.P., Bihar, M.P. and Rajasthan, in order of magnitude. The rise of Hindu chauvinism, unchecked by government, has given rein to assorted petty bigotries.

There are signs of an incipient Dalit backlash against the injustice of being obliged to do unpleasant work to make a living and then being assaulted for doing it. After the Gujarat incident one group of Dalits in the state has flatly refused to continue with its traditional profession of disposing of dead cows. 'If the cow is your mother,' they asked upper-caste Hindus, 'why don't you bury her?'